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Different emphases, same positions? The election manifestos of political parties in the EU multilevel electoral system compared

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Abstract
Political parties increasingly operate at multiple political levels. Nevertheless, we do not yet know much about the consequences of these multilevel electoral systems (MLESs) on party behaviour. To fill this gap, we examine party manifestos for European Parliament (EP) elections and compare them with party manifestos for national elections. Using manifesto data and covering 15 European Union (EU) countries between 1979 and 2014, we focus on European issues and ask whether parties' issue emphasis and the positions they take are the same in both kinds of documents and respectively at both levels of the MLES. We show that although parties put more emphasis on EU issues in EP than in national elections, they behave sincerely regarding their position towards the EU – these are very similar irrespective of the electoral context. As many elections take place in MLES environments, in Europe, in particular, but far beyond, this noteworthy finding is highly relevant for scholars of party competition in general and even more instructive for the so far fragmented literature exploring the implications of MLESs.

Keywords
European Parliament, European Union, issue salience, multilevel electoral systems, party position

Introduction

For a long time, political parties primarily operated in nearly isolated electoral systems. Accordingly, political scientists studied party competition within such settings. Party competition hinges on the political issues which parties emphasize and the positions they take on controversial ones. Two key theories have been formulated to investigate what kind of issues parties emphasize and what positions they take. The baseline model is the smallest distance model according to which parties position themselves on relevant issues where they can expect to maximize their support (Downs, 1957; for many subsequent analyses, see Enelow and Hinich, 1984). The issue emphasis theory (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996; Petrocik et al., 2003), by contrast, claims that parties compete for support by putting emphasis on those issues that promote their strong points while avoiding issues that are opportune to their opponents. However, political parties increasingly operate in multiple electoral arenas (Golder et al., 2017). They simultaneously operate in the regional and the national arena (Klingelhöfer, 2014; Müller, 2013), while at the same time competing in the European arena (Ladrech, 2002, 2010: 128–145). This perspective is far from novel. Already some decades ago, Reif and Schmitt (1980) pointed to the fact that elections to the European Parliament (EP) do not work independently from national elections and that this may have considerable consequences

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for the strategic behaviour of political parties.[1] Nevertheless, the fact that political parties are not only operating at one single political level but in multilevel electoral systems (MLESs) (Deschouwer, 2003; Schmitt and Van der Eijk, 2008; Van Houten, 2009) so far has not attracted widespread scholarly attention. Only very recently, Golder et al. (2017: 2) point to this lacuna:

> The existence of these multiple electoral arenas suggests that scholars should be cautious about examining single levels in isolation, because the behaviour of both party elites and voters in one arena is not independent of what happens in another.

The fact that in contemporary European politics the vast majority of political parties compete in MLESs asks for a more profound understanding of this phenomenon. Consequently, the general aim of this study is to investigate party competition across electoral levels. More specifically, we seek to compare issue positions and issue emphases of political parties at different electoral levels. We chose to study the multilevel system of governance of the European Union (EU) (Hooghe and Marks, 2001) which involves several jurisdictions that are governed by way of general elections. Of course, a multitude of empirical studies is available for this prominent and well-known example of an MLES. Nevertheless, most research has been concentrating on electoral behaviour, whereas scholars devoted much less attention to the supply side of political competition. Which positions parties take at the EU level compared to that of national politics and whether and to what extent these issues are emphasized at the different levels are questions that have been largely ignored so far. Political parties establish a crucial link between citizens and the government (Dalton et al., 2011). It is essential to understand how these main political actors behave in an MLES. We address these research questions in the current article.

To answer these questions, we study manifesto data provided by the MARPOR project (Volkens et al., 2017) as well as by the Euromanifesto Project (Schmitt et al., 2018). Based on earlier scholarship, we develop two basic assumptions and test them for 15 EU member countries for the period between 1979 and 2014. To be able to present a clear-cut comparative study on party behaviour in MLES, we decided to concentrate our analysis on one particular issue – the European integration issue – which, over the past years, has become a highly salient subject of public controversy in party politics. This has been suggested by recent scholarly work around the politicization of Europe (e.g. Hutter et al., 2016), but also more theoretically as part of the 'issue yield theory' (De Sio and Weber, 2014; De Sio et al., 2017) and its character of a 'wedge issue' (Van de Wardt et al., 2014). Hence, investigating whether the parties' issue emphases and the positions they take on EU issues are the same in both electoral arenas and, therefore, in both kinds of documents contributes to the literature in two important directions: First and foremost, we add to the analysis of party competition in MLES. Second, our analysis contributes to the further understanding of party competition over EU issues.

Political parties and European issues

For EP elections, the conventional wisdom is that they 'are fought not as "European elections" but [...] are in fact about national political issues [...]' (Hix and Høyland, 2011: 157). But the politicization of European integration is an ongoing process. In fact, empirically, we do not know much about the question of how 'Europeanized' or 'nationalized' the election to the EP is at different times and places (Guinaudeau and Persico, 2013). Only very recently, two European-wide comparative studies shed some light on this question illustrating that EU issue salience in EP elections is indeed higher than expected (Spoon, 2012). This is so in particular when considering not only constitutional but also European level policy issues (Braun et al., 2016). These findings, obviously, challenge the conventional wisdom that EP elections are about national issues related to the agenda of national governments. At least in EP elections, European issues seem to play a more important role than presumed in past scholarship. Borrowing insights from studies focusing on national instead of EP elections, we can expand these findings with some additional evidence. From two case studies, comparing German (Brunsbach et al., 2012) and Italian election manifestos (Kritzinger et al., 2004) on both levels of jurisdiction, we know that in both electoral arenas European issues are perhaps not the key issues, but parties do put strong emphasis on them (see also Wüst and Binder, 2004; Wüst and Schmitt, 2007). More specifically, for the cases of France, Britain and Germany, Guinaudeau and Persico (2013) show that 8.7% of the national election manifesto content from 1986 to 2009 was devoted to EU issues. For the case of Austria, Senninger and Wagner (2015) show that parties addressed European issues in about 9% of their press releases during national election campaigns in 2008 and 2013. However, the question whether the EU issue emphasis of political parties is comparable between different jurisdictions still remains unanswered.

Different political outlets follow their own communication logic. We should, therefore, not be surprised that it may make a difference whether we take our findings from manifesto data, media data or expert surveys. In analysing media data collected during national elections campaigns, Kriesi (2007) shows that opposition parties in EU-sceptic countries put more emphasis on EU issues than others and thus are the main drivers of the process of politicization. Based on a larger sample of media content data from 61 national elections in 6 West European countries, Hutter et al. (2016) find that EU constitutive issues are the main drivers of politicization. Other studies investigating EP

elections through the lenses of the media and their election campaign coverage show that the political debate can largely be described as domestic – while indicating some weak trends towards more emphasis on EU issues in later EP elections (Boomgaarden and De Vreese, 2016; Boomgaarden et al., 2013; De Vreese, 2003; De Vreese, 2007; Schuck et al., 2011). Accordingly, Adam and Maier (2011, 2016) conclude that party campaigns are not of a purely second-order election (SOE) nature any more because right-wing mobilization against the EU makes the EU issue more salient than in the past.

To sum up, we know a lot about EU issue emphasis in EP as well as in national elections, but to the best of our knowledge, there is no cross-national comparative study that systematically compares the parties' issue emphasis across different electoral levels. Although our short overview may reveal to some degree that parties put more emphasis on EU issues in EP elections than in national elections, we simply do not know whether this is really the case. A similar conclusion can be drawn on party positions. In particular, in terms of party positions towards the EU, scholars produced a multitude of interesting findings: Initially, EU positioning was explained based on the left–right positions of political parties as well as the party family they belong to. Liberal as well as Christian Democratic Party families have been identified as pro-European parties, whereas parties from the far right and far left are described as anti-European parties (Hix and Lord, 1997; Marks et al., 2002). But more recently, together with the conceptualization of the GAL-TAN dimension (Hooghe et al., 2002) and the integration–demarcation cleavage (Kriesi et al., 2006; 2008), it becomes clear that European issues cut across the traditional left–right dimension. However, parties that are centrist on the left–right dimension are known to have more pro-European stances, whereas parties from the extremes tend to be characterized by anti-European positions (e.g. Hix and Høyland, 2011). Although these findings are part of a wider scholarly debate (for a more detailed discussion, see recently Prosser, 2016), we can take the famous 'inverted u-curve' (e.g. Hooghe et al., 2002) as one of the most stable insights on European party competition. However, the question whether parties' positions towards the EU are similar in EP elections and in national first-order elections lacks empirical investigation so far. In the next section, we argue that such a comparative view is necessary and elaborate on testable hypotheses for such a comparative undertaking.

Theoretical assumptions on party behaviour in MLESs

There remains a significant gap in knowledge on party competition in MLES. From a normative point of view, this is highly relevant as political parties are crucial for democratic representation, in particular in times of ongoing debates over rising levels of political disaffection. Accordingly, these actors need to be credible in the eyes of their voters. We know for instance that voters rely on party brand names when they cast their ballot (Grynaviski, 2010). Credibility would suffer if parties would appear as fundamentally volatile in terms of both issue priorities and positions. This in consequence could cause increasing disaffection with political parties among citizens. The next two sections will illustrate in more detail how these general thoughts may relate to parties' emphasis on and their position towards EU issues in MLES.

EU issue emphasis

According to salience theory, political parties put emphasis on issues and policies in which they are perceived most competent and their claims most credible (Budge and Farlie, 1983; Petrocik, 1996; Petrocik et al., 2003). This basically means that parties strategically emphasize issues to gain votes. Applying this to the logic of MLESs, we would assume that parties perceive each electoral level as a separate opportunity to emphasize issues because of divergent possibilities (but see also Golder et al., 2017: 8).[2] What does this mean for parties EU issue emphasis in MLES?

A first guess would be that parties put more emphasis on EU issues in EP elections. This also fits with some of the results reported earlier where we found that European issues are more prevalent in EP elections than widely assumed. As the SOE model does not expect such arena-specific issue emphases, but assumes that EP elections are dominated by national political issues much in the same way as national elections are, this expectation may seem surprising. But it is based on two important considerations: First, precisely because these contests are considered to be SOE (Reif and Schmitt, 1980), and second, because the European integration issue is considered to be highly conflictive and parties tend to de-emphasize conflictive issues (e.g. Green-Pedersen, 2012; Rovny, 2012). In these less important elections of the members of the EP, parties might be less constrained to put emphasis on EU issues. In contrast, due to the conflictive nature of the EU issue, political parties should be more hesitant to put emphasis on these issues in national elections where more is at stake. Or, to put it differently, while in national elections, strategic party competition plays a more explicit role, the idea that parties are motivated by the goals of votes, office or policy (Müller and Strom, 1999) is of less avail in the case of the European arena, where 'elections to the EP do not determine a European government' (Ladrech, 2012: 50). This has not fundamentally changed with the increasing significance of EP elections following the Lisbon treaty, as the introduction of the *Spitzenkandidaten* system did not fully realize the desired effect on party competition (Braun and Popa, 2018; Braun and Schwarzbözl, 2018; Schmitt et al., 2015). In addition to these considerations with regard to

the strategic behaviour of political parties, it has been recognized earlier that '[w]e must not, however, conclude that national aspects alone shape the activities and decisions taken at second-order elections' (Reif and Schmitt, 1980: 10). Our theoretical assumption regarding EU issue emphasis in MLES can be thus formulated as follows:

> **H1**: We expect political parties' emphasis on EU issues to be higher in EP than in national elections because of the issues at stake at the different levels of the MLES as well as strategic motivations instigated by the different levels of the MLES.

Party positions towards EU issues

Starting from Downs' spatial model of party competition (Downs, 1957), we know that parties compete with one another by adopting specific policy positions in order to maximize their vote share. In order to achieve this goal, parties need to be credible to their voters. Given that empirical evidence confirms that policy preferences are one of the factors causing vote choices, (at least some) voters would be bewildered and even alienated if parties visibly changed their position towards major political issues. This could potentially lead to a changing vote decision of these voters no matter at what level of the MLES. Consequently, political parties are assumed to have an incentive to be consistent between jurisdictions with regard to their positions towards major policy issues. To achieve their major goals, they need to ensure the clarity of their positions in different electoral arenas and over different types of elections (Klingelhöfer, 2014; Müller, 2013). However, this is only one way of approaching the question of how parties position themselves in different election arenas. In addition to that, we need to have in mind that politicians and their parties from different levels of jurisdiction are interconnected. Resulting from this linkage, they benefit, for instance, from the shared brand name and the reputation which is associated with this brand name (Grynaviski, 2010: 51). Accordingly, parties should have an additional incentive to bring all of their (sub and supranational) branches acting in line with the policies of their national party organization. Parties are thus expected to coordinate their positions towards all major issues – as in our case the European integration issue – across different electoral arenas.

> **H2**: We expect political parties' EU position to be the same no matter which type of election in the MLES is contested because of the necessary clarity of positions of political parties in the face of their voters.

To sum up, we started our theoretical inquiry with the idea that political parties are crucial for democratic representation and thus need to exhibit credibility to their voters. This credibility would suffer if parties appear volatile, and thus unreliable, in terms of their issue priorities and positions. The theoretical discussion illustrates that both the particular requirements of the MLES *and* the strategic considerations of political parties within this MLES should lead to a differential EU issue emphasis, but to similar positions. The aim of this study is to investigate these two assumptions empirically.

Data and methods

Data

In order to examine the salience of European issues as well as the position that a party is taking towards Europe in national first-order elections, we use data from the Comparative Manifesto Project (formerly MRG, now MARPOR project) (Volkens et al., 2017). For EP elections, we use manifesto data as well as the *Euromanifesto*[3] database (Schmitt et al., 2018).

But what does manifesto data actually measure? First and foremost, in their manifestos, parties explain the policies which they advocate to enact when elected in parliaments and governments (Budge et al., 2001; Klingemann et al., 1994). These campaign documents commonly represent the collective internal expression of political parties' policy preferences (Ceron, 2012). Furthermore, manifestos are campaign instruments: in the elaboration of their positions, parties therefore consider the stances of their potential supporters on general and on European issues (Adams et al., 2004; Popa and Dumitrescu, 2017). Finally, election manifestos are drafted by a rather small group of experts within a party. However, in most if not all, cases they are then discussed, amended and approved by party delegates at large. We therefore can act on the assumption that the content of election manifestos reflects the official position that a party assumes on specific issues. While only a negligible fraction of the citizenry actually reads these documents, people pay attention to the elite communication concerning them and the media coverage of them (Topf, 1994)

While manifesto data are therefore an appropriate data source to map parties' policy preferences, and in our case to compare their preferences towards EU-related matters in MLESs, we acknowledge that these kinds of data are certainly not the only one available. As we already alluded to, other data sources rely on media generated information on parties' issue emphases and positions. Due to the fact that not all issues raised in party manifestos make it into the media reporting and public debate (e.g. Adam and Maier, 2011; De Vreese, 2007; Hutter et al., 2016; Kriesi et al., 2008), these alternative sources may be characterized as less authoritative and more selective.

Parties and elections

The unit of observation in our analysis are parties' election manifestos (the national one and the *Euromanifesto*) in a country X issued ahead of an election Y. Since the first elections to the EP were held in 1979 and then on 5-year intervals, we have *Euromanifesto* data for eight elections (1979, 1984, 1989, 1994, 1999, 2004, 2009 and 2014). To compare national and EP elections systematically and comprehensively, we use MARPOR data from the closest national election preceding the EP election in question (see Table A1 in the Online supplemental appendix I). Alltogether the party sample for national and EP elections comprises 989 cases in 15 Western EU member states.[4] From this overall sample, some parties are excluded from the analysis because they did not gain a seat in EP elections although they did in national elections, or vice versa (245 parties gained a seat in EP elections, but not in national ones; 216 gained a seat in national, but not in EP elections). Those parties that gained a seat only in EP elections are particularly interesting, because these are mostly new or very small parties that gained importance only in EP elections, for example, because they take EU-critical stances and are indeed purely European 'products' (e.g. *Junilistan* in Sweden or *Folkebevægelsen Mod EU* in Denmark). In the end, the number of remaining manifesto dyads (*Euromanifestos* for which we also have MARPOR data to compare with) is 528 for 15 countries and 8 points in time (see Online supplemental appendix I, Table A3).

Measurement of EU issue salience and party positioning towards the EU

The MARPOR data set provides two different coding categories in this regard: 'European Integration: Positive' and 'European Integration: Negative'. The positive category is coded in the case of 'Favourable mentions of European Community/Union in general; desirability of expanding the European Community/Union and/or of increasing its competence; desirability of expanding the competences of the European Parliament; desirability of the manifesto country joining (or remaining a member)' (Volkens et al., 2013: 9). The negative category is used in the following cases: 'Hostile mentions of the European Community/Union; opposition to specific European policies which are preferred by European authorities; opposition to the net contribution of the manifesto country to the EU budget; otherwise as 108, but negative' (Volkens et al., 2013: 9). Since the *Euromanifesto Project* was initiated to code the content of election programmes of parties campaigning for seats in the EP, a number of additional coding categories has been developed in this study for more specific aspects of, and arguments relating to, the political system of the EU: competences of the EP, competences of the European Commission, majority voting in the (European) Council, competences of the European Court of Justice, EC/EU enlargement and complexity of the EC/EU political system (for each coding category positive and negative mentions). Although the coding categories are roughly comparable between the two different data sources, it becomes obvious that the variables differ to some degree. In order to ensure comparability, we use the two EC/EU coding categories in the MARPOR data as a baseline and create two composite indices for the *Euromanifesto* data of which one has a positive connotation and the other a negative one.

We take the sum over the mentions of our additional coding categories to construct a general measure of *EU issue salience* in national and EP elections. To identify *party positions towards Europe* in EP elections, we create a new variable using the ratio measure known from previous studies (e.g. Marks et al., 2007). This is calculated through dividing the sum of all positive mentions by the sum of all positive and negative mentions.[5] The dependent variables of our analysis which we compare across electoral arenas and over time are accordingly (a) the emphasis that parties put on European issues and (b) the position they take towards the EU measured via party manifestos issued ahead of EP and national elections. Some basic descriptive statistics (mean scores) for our dependent variable is provided in Online supplemental appendix I, Table A2.

Empirical analysis: Different emphases, same positions

The aim of this section is to test our two basic theoretical assumptions by comparing EU issue emphasis and party positions towards Europe in EP elections and in national elections (i.e. in MLES) – gained through the respective party manifestos.

We assumed in H1 that parties differ in the emphasis they put on EU matters in EP and national elections. A simple *t*-test statistic, assessing whether the means of our groups – EU issue emphasis in EP and national elections – are statistically different from each other, provides first information on this question. For more than 500 parties under study, the mean value for EU issue emphasis in EP elections is at 18.3 (with 95% confidence intervals at 17.4–19.2), meaning that 18.3% of the entire Euromanifesto (EM) is dedicated to European matters. In contrast, the mean value for EU issue emphasis in national elections is at 3.2 (with 95% confidence intervals at 2.9–3.4): Accordingly, only 3.2% of the average national manifesto are dedicated to European matters.[6]

Hence, a very general investigation into our research question reveals that political parties put much less emphasis on European matters in national than in EP elections. Figure 1 illustrates these findings for all parties in a scatterplot where the *y*-axis represents the parties' emphasis on EU issues in national elections and the *x*-axis their EU issue emphasis in EP elections ($r = 1.19$). The findings mirror

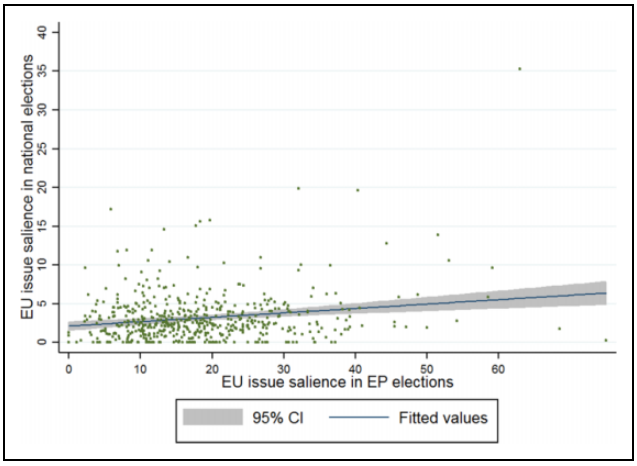


Figure 1. EU issue emphasis by political parties in EP and national elections (correlation matrix). The figure plots EU issue salience in EP and national elections. For EU issue salience in EP elections, we used Euromanifesto data (Schmitt et al., 2018), and for EU issue salience in national elections, we used data from the Comparative Manifesto Project (Volkens et al., 2017). EU: European Union; EP: European Parliament.

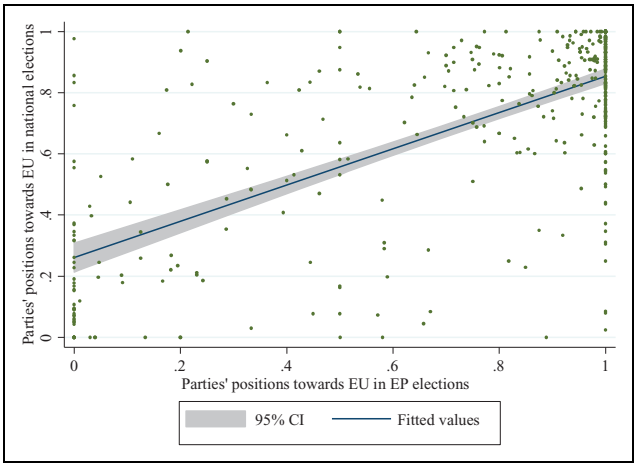


Figure 2. Party position towards the EU in EP and national elections (correlation matrix). The figure plots the parties' positions towards the EU in EP and national elections, with '0' indicating anti-EU stances and '1' pro-EU stances. For information on data sources, see Figure 1. EU: European Union; EP: European Parliament.

the rather general results described earlier although now with a particular eye on the party level: First, there is no statistically significant relationship between the salience of EU issues in *Euromanifestos* and national election manifestos. Second, the graph clearly shows that most parties put much more emphasis on EU issues in EP elections than in national elections. In the majority of the cases, parties devote less than 10% of their national manifestos to EU issues, whereas they dedicate 10–30% of the overall space in EP election manifestos to EU issues. Of course, there are some exceptions to this rule: 11 from the altogether 528 parties put more emphasis on EU issues in national than in EP elections. This happens, for example, in Luxembourg (1994: Democratic Party) or Italy (1994: National Alliance; 1999: Communist Refoundation Party; 2009: Union of the Center). However, this is clearly the minority of cases (for a detailed overview on the party emphases on EU issues in EP and national elections see in the Online supplemental appendix I, Table A3). The take-home lesson here is that parties devote much more space to European issues in EP elections compared to national elections. Accordingly, H1 can be corroborated.

While we have shown that EU issue salience of political parties differs significantly between EP and national elections, we have argued that the position a party takes towards the EU should be about the same no matter in which type of election. This is required for political parties as they strive to be credible towards their voters. As the same voters are involved in the electoral contests at the two levels, they would easily recognize inconsistencies in parties' policy stances. Again, we first consult a *t*-test statistic to assess the differences in means between the party position in EP and national elections. The mean value for the party position towards Europe in the case of EP election manifestos is at 0.71 (with 95% confidence interval between 0.69 and 0.74), and we find almost the same (0.76) in the case of national election manifestos (with 95% confidence interval between 0.73 and 0.80).[7] This shows that there is no significant difference between party positions on Europe in EP and national elections, meaning that the EU position of parties is identical in both elections.[8] While these results rather concern the overall pattern, Figure 2 validates them also for the party level illustrating party positions towards Europe using a scatterplot. Again, the *y*-axis represents values for national elections and the *x*-axis values for EP election. This time the regression line identifies a clear link between the parties' positions in the two electoral arenas. Although a number of parties express negative positions, most of them take positive stances towards the EU. But what is most important here, they stay with this position at the different levels of the MLES.

Nevertheless, it cannot be overlooked that some parties also take different positions in the two electoral arenas, a fact that leads to a correlation coefficient of 0.69. In our opinion, two different explanations account for this less-than-perfect correlation. One reason could be of course that the two different data sources – MARPOR and Euromanifesto data – differ somewhat with regard to the measurement strategy of the dependent variables. However, a second reason can be identified by a careful look at the data: Whereas the overwhelming majority of party positional dyads (395 of 528) deviate only to a very small or small degree from each other (i.e. one or two standard deviations or less), a minority of party positional dyads

seems to be responsible for the less-than-perfect correlation presented earlier.

Put differently, 395 of our cases are rather close in terms of their position towards the EU in EP and national elections. An example here is the case of the UK Labour Party in 2009 which dedicated 11.4% of their Euromanifestos to pro-EU topics and 1.8% to negative references of the EU. In national election manifestos, they dedicated 2.3% to EU-positive and 0.2% to EU-critical mentions. These values result in a very similar positive position towards the EU in national (0.93) and EP elections (0.86) for this party. Comparable cases are the German Social Democratic Party (all elections except 1984) with high values and the UK Independence Party (2014, 2019) with low values – in the different arenas of the MLES of the EU. In contrast, for 133 of the overall 528 cases, the deviation of the party position in the two types of elections amounts to more than 2 standard deviations. These parties indeed take different positions in EP and national elections. Some examples for these strong deviations are eye-catching in the case of populist parties such as the Austrian *Freiheitliche Partei Österreichs* (FPÖ) in 1999 and 2004, the Belgiam *Vlaams Bloc* (1989) and later *Vlaams Belang* (2014) who take rather positive stance towards the EU in national elections but negative stances in EP elections. But to be clear, not only populist parties shape these deviating findings but also parties such as the *Lëtzebuerger Sozialistesch Aarbechterpartei* (LSAP) from Luxembourg in 1989 or the UK Conservatives in 1989 (for a detailed overview on the party position over EU issues in EP and national elections, see Online supplemental appendix I, Table A3).

Conclusions

Our empirical analysis of EU issue salience and party positions over Europe has clearly shown that parties put less emphasis on EU matters in national election manifestos than in Euromanifestos, whereas they take a rather similar position towards the EU in both electoral arenas.[9] According to our theoretical assumptions, this pattern can be explained by differing strategies applied by political parties at the different levels of the MLES. As many elections take place in MLES environments, in Europe in particular, but far beyond, this finding is highly important for different strands of literature.

First, our findings add to a so far very fragmented literature on multilevel electoral politics. This perspective appears to be highly important against the background of the increasing dispersion of political authority across levels (Golder et al., 2017). Although we started with the idea that parties' credibility would suffer if they appeared unreliable in terms of both issue priorities and positions, we already limited this normatively charged guess. Because of arena-specific considerations (i.e. different issues at stake) as well as strategic motivations instigated by the different levels of the MLES, the credibility argument in the case of parties' emphasis of EU issues has been thus balanced. Empirically, we found that parties' EU issue emphasis differs at different levels of the MLES. The reasons for this can be twofold: First, in EP elections, less is at stake; parties thus do not need to strategically de-emphasize the potentially conflictive EU issues. Second, EP elections are held at the EU level and thus need to address European issues, whereas in national elections the EU integration issue is one among many others. On the other hand, strategic behaviour may be particularly relevant in terms of the party's position: They need to be credible vis-à-vis the citizenry at large and their voters and, therefore, try to avoid changing their issue positions over different elections. In any case, parties can only slowly change issue positions over time in order to avoid severe electoral damage.[10]

Second, scholars of party competition in Europe will need to take these findings into account in their future studies on the politicization of Europe (e.g. Hutter et al., 2016) or on the relevance of European issues for voting decisions (e.g. De Vries, 2010). Our findings clearly show that parties devote a significant proportion of their *Euromanifestos* to EU issues, whereas they abstain from doing so in their manifestos for national first-order elections. This pattern is rather stable over time and thus underpins recent findings (Braun et al., 2016; Spoon, 2012). Based on empirical evidence we are finally able to challenge the conventional wisdom that political parties do not speak about European issues in EP elections. This analysis illustrates that political parties indeed raise European issues in their election manifestos at the European level, despite the seeming lack of importance of this electoral contest. In addition, our comparative approach adds another brick to Mair's (2007) hunch on the way political parties emphasize EU issues in the different arenas of the EU multilevel system. Parties put more emphasis on constitutive issues (our measurement of EU issues here is mainly based on what he would call constitutive issues) in EP elections than in national elections. According to Mair (2007), in order to finally arrive at a genuine party competition at the EU level, things should be the other way round as political actors in the national arena are the ones to finally decide on these constitutive issues.

Third, when comparing our findings to empirical studies using media data, which show that there has been a modest trend towards higher EU issue salience at least in the more recent EP elections (e.g. Adam and Maier, 2011; Boomgaarden and De Vreese, 2016; Schuck et al., 2011), scholars need to think about the discrepancies between measures of EU issue salience in media discourses and in party manifestos. Apparently, political parties raise EU issues in EP election manifestos, but for some reason, which might be based on a limited news value (Meyer et al., 2017) as well as different strategic decisions of

political parties (for instance because there is no substantive intra-party debate over Europe; Guinaudeau and Palau, 2016), these issues do not make it into the public debate. These two puzzles certainly need thorough attention in future scholarly work and might help to better understand party competition at the EU level of governance.

Finally, the attentive reader might of course ask in which way our findings are instructive for party competition more generally. Recent research in this field was putting forward the idea that parties tend to blur their positions (Rovny, 2012) or assume a broad-appeal strategy with the main aim of maximizing their votes (Somer-Topcu, 2015). Taking into account the idea of political parties operating within MLESs, our results add to these findings. We can confirm that parties are certainly strategic actors. In order to maximize their votes, they even strive for consistency regarding their positions at different levels of the MLES although this involves a greater equalizing effort. But, obviously, we cannot say much about whether our findings apply for different political issues or other jurisdictional levels at play. Against this background, future research will need to investigate the position taking of parties over multiple issue dimensions at different levels of MLESs. Moreover, future studies not only will need to address this phenomenon at the party-system level (what we have done in this article) but add some analysis at the party level because we 'do not expect that all parties make the same strategic choices with respect to which electoral arena is most crucial' (Golder et al., 2017: 16).

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Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. In the case of interdependencies between national and European Parliament (EP) elections, we know that – as compared to national first-order elections – less is at stake in the second-order EP elections and that, therefore, turnout as well as the vote share of government parties is lower while that of smaller and ideologically more extreme parties is higher (Reif, 1984; Reif and Schmitt, 1980).
2. This assumption could be supported if different people are responsible for the writing process of the manifestos. A non-representative enquiry among political parties confirms this idea. While in the case of subnational elections, the subnational party officials are responsible for compiling the manifestos, and this is slightly different for EP elections. As in the case of national elections, national party officials prepare the Euromanifestos, but they do this only after gathering information from party representatives devoted to European Union (EU) topics. Therefore, responsibility is split to some degree in terms of the writing process of EP and national-level manifestos.
3. The *Euromanifesto* project is a constituent part of the ongoing European Election Studies (for more information, including data availability, see www.ees-homepage.net). It is based on the MARPOR methodology but is focusing on the content of EP election manifestos of political parties rather than that of national election manifestos.
4. We opted for the exclusion of the countries that joined the EU in the 2000s because we are interested in the first place in the comparison between EP and national elections. This comparison would be challenged by the fact that party systems in Central and Eastern European countries are still considered less consolidated with regard to both national and EP elections (Schmitt, 2005).
5. Important to note is that the creation of this indicator leads to a number of additional missing cases mostly for party positions based on MAPOR data ($N = 62$), but also for Euromanifesto data ($N = 4$). This is due to the fact that these parties do not put any emphasis on EU issues in their manifestos and are thus excluded from further analysis (see also Online supplemental appendix I, Table A3).
6. For the sake of clarity, Online supplemental appendix I, Figure A1 illustrates this remarkable statistically significant finding graphically for the different years and countries under consideration.
7. Accordingly, the variation in party positions in national elections (with SD at 0.35 and variance (Var) at 0.12) is slightly higher than in EP elections (with SD at 0.30 and Var at 0.09).
8. Again, to give an unambiguous idea of this clear-cut pattern, Online supplemental appendix I, Figure A2 illustrates the finding graphically for the different elections and countries: The position parties take towards the EU does not differ between EP and national elections – neither across countries nor across different elections.
9. This is even the case if we consider the dynamic nature of the particular case of our multilevel electoral system (MLES). It

is certainly important to take this dynamic nature, elsewhere aptly described as "moving target" (Hooghe and Marks, 2008: 123), into account when dealing with European integration issues. To be more specific: Over the years, the EU gained greater legislative powers in many policy domains (Hooghe and Marks, 2001; Schmitt and Toygür, 2016). It is argued that this long-term trend in institutional powers has either no particular implications, meaning that EU issue salience remains stable over time (Braun et al., 2016; Spoon, 2012), or increases to some degree over time in both election types (De Vries et al., 2011; Hutter et al., 2016), or it is driven by particular events at the EU level (Kriesi, 2016). Within a robustness check of our findings, we control for these dynamics and test whether they have an impact on our two dependent variables, EU issue salience and the party position towards the EU, and in particular on the relationship between these two phenomena at the EU level and the national level of the MLES (see in detail in the Online supplemental appendix II). Running regression models based on the Prais–Winsten transformation technique, we consider three different variables to grasp the mentioned dynamics appropriately: election years, policy scope of the EU and closeness of critical steps of European integration to the election under consideration. The results (Online supplemental appendix II, Tables 1 and 2) show that the relationship between the two levels is not affected by any of these control variables. Accordingly, our main findings that parties put less emphasis on EU matters in national elections than in EP elections, whereas they take a similar position towards the EU in both electoral arenas and are stable in this regard. Moreover, we still have a statistically significant relationship between the party position towards the EU in EP elections and national elections (Online supplemental appendix II, Table 3).

10. Related to this insight it might be interesting to know how these two dimensions of party strategy are linked to each other. Although a simple correlation analysis offers a significant, but only modest effect ($r = 0.19$), indicating that the higher the differences in salience, the more variation in party positions among levels, future studies could use this finding as a starting point and investigate the linkage of these two important dimensions of party competition for more other issues.

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